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Black Hat Week: The Agent Gets a Chaperone

Data-security companies bought identity companies twice in three days, and about thirty product launches pointed the same direction.





— THE DEALS

About \$1.2 billion, three days, one idea: buy the thing that governs what an AI agent may do.

- July 28. **Cyera**, a data-security company valued at \$12 billion in June, announced it is acquiring Israeli machine-identity company **Oasis Security** for about \$1 billion, roughly \$700 million of it cash. Cyera confirmed the figure to SecurityWeek and CRN.
- July 30. **Okta** signed a definitive agreement to acquire **Permiso Security**, which detects identity threats across human, machine and AI-agent accounts. Okta did not disclose terms. TechCrunch reported just under \$200 million, almost all cash, and Okta did not dispute it.
- July 31. **Cisco** quietly closed its **WideField Security** acquisition, its second identity close in five weeks after Astrix.
- A data-security company, an identity incumbent and a networking giant all moved in the same direction in one week.



— THE PATTERN

Black Hat was not about autonomy. It was about governed autonomy.

Five tracked vendors shipped near-identical ideas on August 3. **Varonis** Agent Intent-Based Access Control checks an agent's reasoning and data access against the task it was given, and can quarantine the identity when they diverge. **Cyera** Agent Guardian extends the same guardrails onto employee laptops. **Mimecast** delivers it through Incydr, **Netskope** through a unified control plane, and **SentinelOne** by making its AI act inside team-set limits, every action reversible.

- CSO Online's read: the industry is "moving beyond simply adding copilots to existing products."
- Our read, and it is an interpretation: the category is shifting from *classify the data, then write a policy* to *infer the actor's intent, then judge the action*. Symantec, Digital Guardian and Forcepoint enterprise data-loss prevention made no announcement we could find this week.



— THE MONEY

Roughly \$960 million went into security challengers in seven days.

- **Horizon3.ai** \$250 million at more than \$2 billion. **ThreatLocker** \$190 million. **Zenity** \$125 million, led by Norwest with SoftBank Vision Fund 2, Hitachi and LG.
- **Onyx Security** \$113 million at \$640 million. **Obsidian Security** \$85 million at \$1.1 billion. **Act Security** \$60 million out of stealth. **Inforcer** \$50 million. **AegisAI** \$36 million. **Bloom Security** \$20 million.
- **Hush Security** raised \$30 million with **Akamai** joining as a strategic investor, and says **Kyndryl** has both deployed it internally and begun reselling it.
- That is ten disclosed rounds in one week. Half of them sell control over machine and AI-agent identity.



— THE STRESS

While challengers raised a billion, two incumbents showed capital strain.

- Thoma Bravo backed down in a lender standoff over Proofpoint's roughly \$5 billion loan refinancing, conceding terms including a provision barring collateral-stripping against existing creditors. Bloomberg ties the pushback to investors "increasingly anxious about AI-driven tech disruption."
- Varonis told its own earnings call that "our Q2 upside was limited because of some large deals that slipped at the end of the quarter due to the rumors in the news." As far as we can tell, it is the first time the company has linked June reports of private-equity takeover interest to actual lost revenue. It has since closed some of them, including a seven-figure deal.
- Two of the largest incumbents in data security, watching capital-markets uncertainty turn into commercial friction, in the same week.



— THE PRINTS

Three earnings in 72 hours. Three completely different verdicts.

- **Fortinet** beat and raised. Revenue \$2.05 billion, up 26%, with product revenue up 52%, and full-year guidance lifted to \$8.02 to \$8.18 billion. Shares rose about 10% and five houses raised targets. The catch: after a 104% year, the stock now trades above the average Street target anyway.
- **Check Point** missed. Revenue grew just 1%, product and licence revenue **fell 14%**, and adjusted free cash flow margin dropped to 23.9% from 39.4% a year earlier. Shares fell sharply, by roughly 11%.
- **Varonis** beat, raised guidance on five measures, and **still fell 8.2%** the next session. On this evidence, beating is no longer enough if the market dislikes the shape of the growth.



— MARKET BY MARKET

Seven markets. What moved in each.

INSIDER RISK MANAGEMENT

Mimecast is shipping AI-agent governance through the Incydr insider-risk product it bought, not alongside it. **Exabeam** says it extended behavioural analytics to AI agents.

DATA LOSS PREVENTION

Forcepoint's federal certification is still unresolved, with a corrective-action deadline of August 4 and revocation set for August 5. **Netskope** launched a unified data-security control plane.

DATA SECURITY POSTURE MANAGEMENT

Cyera bought identity for \$1 billion, then shipped an endpoint agent six days later. Most of the rest of the front went silent.

DETECTION AND RESPONSE

Microsoft shipped Project Perception into gated public preview, on schedule. No rival we saw answered it directly. They answered by shipping.

SECURITY SERVICE EDGE

Gartner's new platform report reset the board mid-week. **Netskope** and **Cato Networks** both claim Leader placement for a third year. **Versa** was "recognized in" it.

AI SECURITY

Zenity raised \$125 million. NVIDIA's open alliance grew from 37 members to more than 120, and published a proposal for confidential AI-incident sharing.

IDENTITY

Three acquisitions in four days, plus **Hush**, **Act** and **Onyx** funded on the same machine-identity thesis. **Visa** separately agreed to buy BioCatch for \$2.4 billion.

THE RECEIPTS

Every move here is public and dated.

The sources behind the moves in this carousel:

COMPANY AND PRIMARY ANNOUNCEMENTS

Cisco · Okta · Microsoft · Palo Alto Networks · Varonis · Check Point · Fortinet · Elastic · Cyera · SentinelOne · Mimecast · Cato Networks · HiddenLayer · BeyondTrust · NVIDIA · Linux Foundation · FedRAMP (public notice)

BUSINESS AND TECHNOLOGY PRESS

Reuters · Bloomberg · Financial Times · TechCrunch · CNBC · SecurityWeek · CRN · Dark Reading · Calcalist · Fortune · SDxCentral · SiliconANGLE · CSO Online · TechRepublic · GeekWire · Business Wire · PR Newswire · GlobeNewswire · Benzinga · MarketBeat · StockTitan · Seeking Alpha · Investing.com

Full citations, claim by claim and link checked, available on request.



— THE RADAR

The market told us what it thinks an AI agent is. It is a user who needs a chaperone.

Our State of Cyber 2026 report made seven predictions about where this market is heading. This week added evidence to several of them, and none broke. The next full scorecard lands in mid-August, after the remaining earnings prints.



Read State of Cyber 2026

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